

After the cheese

After the cheese has been politely declined
And the doings of nest-flown children sympathetically dissected
And the photographed cuteness of grandchildren admired with suppressed envy
Then it comes:

Read them your poem!

From the bottom drawer the poem blinks into the yellow light
Feet together, stand up straight, nice and clearly now
It recites itself
And is received in a haze of wine and sleepy bewilderment
And appropriate words are searched for
It is patted on the head
And sent back to bed.

But today it is among the big boys
Grown-up poems, freighted with insight
Raw, poignant, they are taller, smarter:

It rhymes! How quaint!

The poem shrinks on the page
And slides into a corner
No longer knowing if it is funny
Or tragic.

Chris Adie